

A group shaped by pedigree and ambition

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A king that is conquered must see strange looks...': Saki's words couldn't be truer for Germany in the context of World Cup football — a team that won the tournament in 2014 but has since failed to progress beyond the group stage.

There has been uproar within the country, coaches have changed hands, and now the four-time world champion will look to start afresh in the United States of America, Mexico and Canada under young coach Julian Nagelsmann.

The squad boasts firepower in prodigies such as Jamal Musiala and Florian Wirtz — two explosive, attack-minded players who can wreak havoc in the opposition box with their pace.

But Germany's strength lies in its balance between agility and composure. It is here that the muscularity and positioning of Leon Goretzka and captain Joshua Kimmich could prove pivotal. Kimmich, having won the German Cup

and Bundesliga this season, has remained an ever-present pillar in midfield.

Nagelsmann has also had to mend bridges in the dressing room, burying ghosts of the rift with Manuel Neuer that dates back to 2023. The World Cup-winning goalkeeper fell out with the coach during their time at Bayern Munich, and a lot of water has flown under the bridge since.

Neuer announced his international retirement after the 2024 European Championship, but his Champions League exploits — especially his nine saves in Real Madrid vs Bayern Munich this season — are testament to the fact that the old warhorse

has not lost his sheen at 40. Now, set to return to the national team as its No. 1 after nearly two years, Neuer is bound to embolden the Germans, who are looking to turn the corner after years of misery in the tournament.

And the odds favour Germany heavily in its opener, which is slated against debutant Curacao — a team made up



GERMANY

FIFA ranking: 10

Appearances: 20

Best finish: Winner
(1954, 1974, 1990, 2014)

Matches: 112

Wins: 68

Draws: 21

Losses: 23

Goals For: 232

Goals Against: 130

Highest scorer in the squad
Kai Havertz (21 goals)



CURACAO

FIFA ranking: 82

Appearances: Debut

Highest scorer in the squad Leandro Bacuna
(16 goals)

